remember at France 98, the Danish team were staying at a hotel just down the road from us and had their families with them in the same complex. At first, Sven wasn't sure how the English players felt about having family with them, so he asked me, as captain, to sound them out. In Dubai we had activities organized for the kids in the mornings around the pool and barbecues for everyone in the evenings. The families enjoyed each other's company and it helped draw the lads closer together at the same time.

Having Victoria and Brooklyn there left me with a clear head to concentrate on the one thing that mattered, the World Cup, and me being fit for it. I worked with one of the England trainers, Alan Smith, every morning on my own. I was just starting to run, just starting to test the metatarsal injury. I had to try and build up to something near match fitness. I wasn't able to join in with the regular squad training which was going on every day at the same time. The balance was just right in Dubai: hard work and then the beach and some sunshine, with our families there to enjoy it with us.

I still had doubts whether I would be ready to play in our first match against Sweden. Some days I'd wake up feeling ready there and then, others when it just felt I was starting to run out of time. I was desperate to play in a World Cup as England captain. To give myself and the team the best chance, I thought that meant playing from the very first game. Even before I left England, I'd done everything I could to hurry along the mending process. Now, in Dubai, I was able to put weight on the injured foot. As well as starting to run, there was other work to do before I'd be ready just for a training session, never mind for a game. People might have seen pictures of me on a trampoline. I definitely wasn't ready for jumping up and down. Those exercises were about teaching my leg how to balance again. As well as the muscles losing strength, the tendons and ligaments forget how to do their jobs. I'd have to stand on one leg and balance when a ball was thrown to me, then change legs. The next stage after that was to volley the ball back instead of just catching it. At the end of every day, the trainers would sit down with the England doctors and talk through what we'd done. The medical team would do that with every injured player. Then, the doctors would meet up with Sven in the evening to make sure the manager knew exactly how I was doing from day to day.

I was glad to be around the other players who weren't bothered about anything but starting the tournament. Picking up on everybody else's excitement made me feel more positive about what I had to do. I don't know if it was being captain that made me feel older; or being conscious of the experience I had now, four years on from France 98. I liked watching the